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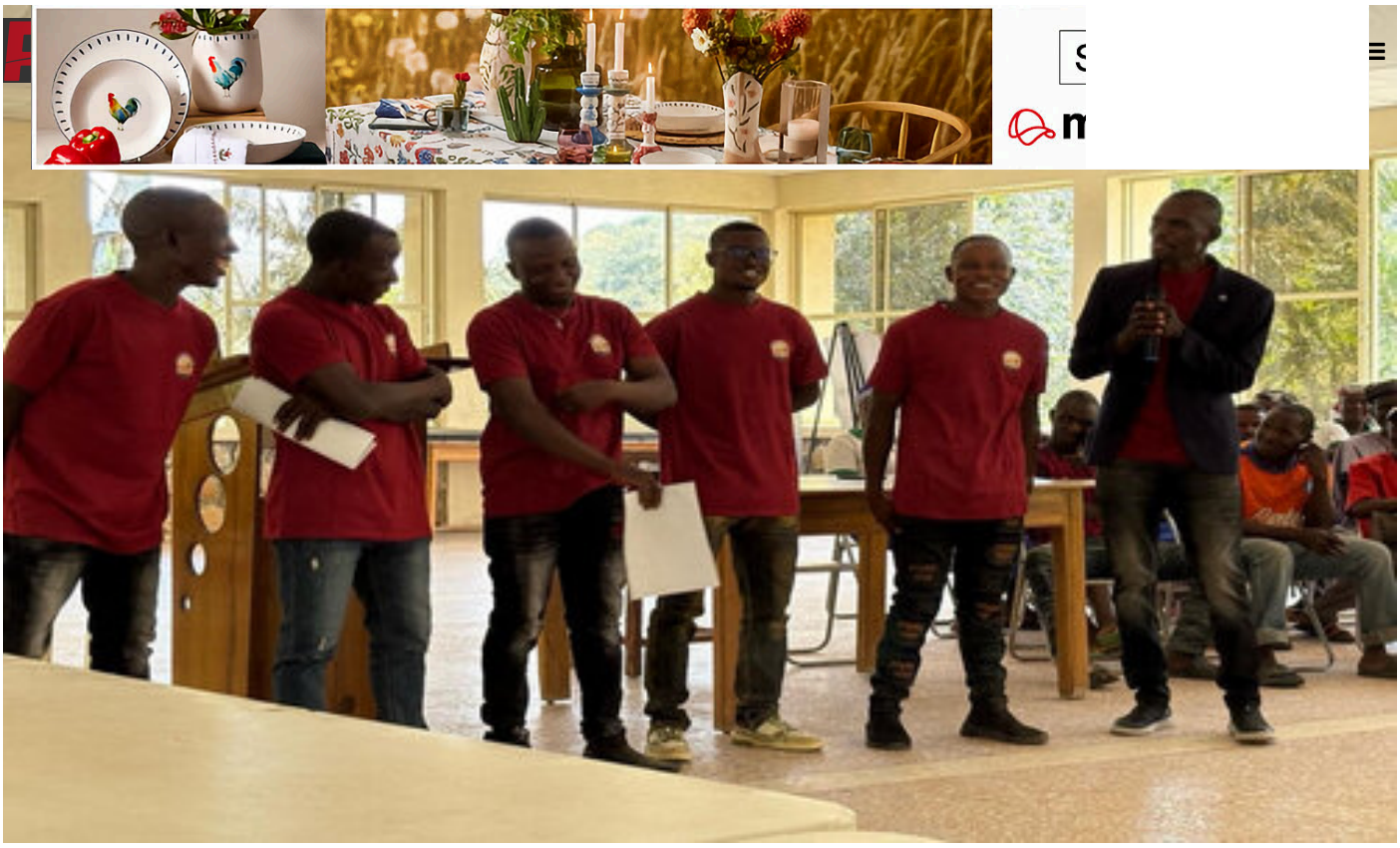
ARTICLE

# He Followed Jesus - Then Drifted Away. What Brought Him Back Changed Everything



BY SPOKEN WORLDWIDE APRIL 09, 2026

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Atiku Ma'aji thought he had found new life.

At 26, he chose to follow Jesus after missionaries came to his village in Nigeria. But his decision came at a cost. His father, a devoted idol worshiper, rejected his faith and forced him from the family home. The local church took him in, and for a time, it seemed like everything had changed.

But it didn't last.

Atiku struggled to understand the Bible. Scripture was available—but not in a way he could fully grasp. It was in languages that felt distant and difficult. Without truly understanding God's Word, his faith never took deep root.

Slowly, he drifted back.

The drinking returned. The reckless lifestyle followed. And the hope he once felt began to fade.

Atiku's story reflects a much larger problem.

Across Nigeria—home to more than 237 million people and over 535 people groups—millions of people learn through listening, not reading. Yet the Bible is often only accessible in written form or in unfamiliar languages. Even when Scripture exists, many people simply cannot understand it.

So faith struggles to take hold.

That's why Spoken Worldwide is doing something different.

Instead of relying on printed text, Spoken Worldwide works with local leaders to translate Scripture into spoken stories in the heart language of the people—and then forms listening groups where communities can hear, discuss, and understand God's Word together.

That's when everything changed for Atiku.

When a Spoken Worldwide listening group launched in his village, Atiku began hearing Scripture in his own language—clearly, naturally, and in a way that finally made sense.

For the first time, God's Word felt personal.

He began to recognize his sin. He understood the truth of the gospel. And this time, his faith took root.

Atiku fully surrendered his life to Christ.

Toc

He is leading.

Now 45 years old, he is married, raising five children, and boldly sharing his testimony wherever he goes. The same man who once struggled to understand Scripture is now helping others hear and believe.

And his story is not an exception—it's a pattern.

When people hear God's Word in a language they truly understand, lives change.

That's exactly what is happening among the Polchi (Pesse) people in Nigeria—a community of about 37,000 people across 45 villages. Like Atiku's village, many rely on oral communication, and access to education is limited. For years, understanding Scripture was a challenge.

But recently, for the first time, the entire New Testament was translated orally into their heart language (https://give.spoken.org/spokenworldwide/icsc8).

Now, instead of struggling to read or relying on unfamiliar languages, people can hear the Bible clearly and naturally.

The response has been overwhelming.

Believers have traveled hours—crowded into pickup trucks over rough roads—just to listen and celebrate hearing God's Word in the language of their hearts.

Because for many, it's the first time it truly makes sense.

This is the mission of Spoken Worldwide (https://give.spoken.org/spokenworldwide/icsc8).

Through oral Bible translation and local listening groups, they are bringing Scripture to people who cannot access it through reading—equipping leaders, discipling communities, and helping faith take root in places where it never could before.

More than 650,000 oral learners have already been reached.

But millions more are still waiting.

Waiting to hear.

Waiting to understand.

Waiting for the same transformation Atiku experienced.

You can help make that possible (https://give.spoken.org/spokenworldwide/icsc8).

Your gift today will help translate Scripture, train local leaders, and launch listening groups in communities where people are ready to hear—but still don't have access.

Give today (https://give.spoken.org/spokenworldwide/icsc8) and help someone hear God's Word for the first time in a way they can truly understand.

Because when that happens … everything changes.

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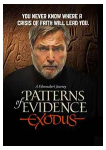


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